

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr Eissa Shirwani

Address: 4 Heyward Court Overton Road Sutton SM2 6JY

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: The plan to convert the Ambulance Station into a place of worship and community centre will bring many benefits to the community. For the last five years, weekly Friday prayers have been held at the hall next to St Johns Church. The hall has a smaller capacity than the proposed extension of the Ambulance Station and also has fewer parking spaces. Despite this, the organisation of weekly Friday prayers, along with monthly talks and night prayers during Ramadan, has run smoothly with little to no instances of disturbance to the local community. Having a larger space with more parking available will create more opportunities for the local community, from hosting talks with doctors and medical specialists to running activities for young people. Sutton and Belmont currently lack these opportunities, especially as many youth centres have closed down.

Moreover, the site will only reach its maximum capacity of 250 on Fridays during the Friday prayers. Throughout the rest of the day, there will be far fewer people attending daily congregational prayers. This shows that parking will not be an issue and there will not be excessive chatter or noise during the day.

The activities already being run at St Johns Church hall by our community have been very successful, from weekly Friday prayers to hosting dinners during Ramadan where both Muslims and non Muslims have attended and enjoyed a meal together while getting to know members of the wider community whom they would not usually interact with. By having our own community centre we can continue to offer this service on a bigger and better scale.

Additionally, the prayers will not coincide with the pick up and drop off times of Avenue students.

This has never been an issue during our Friday prayers, especially during BST when we hold one prayer at around 1:30 and another at 2:30, which is also when Avenue students finish school early at around 2:15 instead of the usual 3:15 finish. During winter timings, no prayer will coincide with this schedule. Therefore, the community centre and Avenue School will be able to exist together peacefully without any disturbance to one another.

Also, the ambulance centre was running 24/7 with ambulances coming and going throughout the day with lights flashing and sirens running. Our community centre will not be running 24/7 and will not make this level of noise disturbance to the community.

Finally, approving this application will allow us to make effective use of an existing building rather than constructing a new one, which will reduce environmental impact and make more sustainable use of local resources.

Allowing the conversion of the Ambulance Station into a community centre will greatly benefit the community and provide a valuable opportunity for integration and bringing people together. It can also serve as a hub for young people, offering activities such as networking workshops, self defence classes, and other programmes that support personal development and positive engagement.

For these reasons, I strongly support the application.